

Report on the Status of Bilingual-Bicultural Education Programs in Wisconsin

December 2025

Wisconsin Department of Public Instruction

Report on the Status of Bilingual-Bicultural Education Programs in Wisconsin, Chapter 115, Subchapter VII, § 115.996, Wis. Stats.

Developed by

Bilingual/English Learner Education Program

Department of Public Instruction

Wisconsin Department of Public Instruction

Jill K. Underly, PhD, State Superintendent

Madison, Wisconsin

This report is available from:

PK-12 Standards and Instruction Section
Greg Coleman, Section Leader
Wisconsin Department of Public Instruction
201 West Washington Avenue
Madison, WI 53703
(608) 665-9281
DPIBilingualBiculturalProgram@dpi.wi.gov

December 2025
Wisconsin Department of Public Instruction

The Wisconsin Department of Public Instruction does not discriminate on the basis of sex, race, color, religion, creed, age, national origin, ancestry, pregnancy, marital status or parental status, sexual orientation, or ability and provides equal access to the Boy Scouts of America and other designated youth groups.

Table of Contents

Report on the Status of Bilingual-Bicultural Education Programs in Wisconsin 1
Background 1
Language Programs and Locations 1
Program Costs for Categorically Aided District Programs 3
Reimbursement Rates over Time 4
Historical Demographic Data and Number of Reclassified Students 4
Data Displays 6
Table 5: 2024-25 Bilingual-Bicultural Education Programs: Students Served by Language 6
Table 6: 2024-25 BLBC Education Programs: District Costs and Reimbursement 6
Table 7: 2024-25 BLBC Education: Student Participation by District and Language 8

Report on the Status of Bilingual-Bicultural Education Programs in Wisconsin

Background

Under Section 115.996, Wisconsin Statutes, the state superintendent is required to report to the legislature on the status of bilingual-bicultural education programs funded under this authority. This report provides the specific information required by law for the 2024-25 school year (paid during FY 2026).

Chapter 115, Subchapter VII, Wisconsin Statutes provides partial, yet critical, funding for English Learner (EL)1 students in the state whose language education needs must be met by the districts in which they are enrolled. It is the only state funding source for students classified as English Learners and supports districts in providing instructional services that foster language proficiency development and leverage students' linguistic assets for academic learning.

It should be noted this report will use the term English Learner (EL) rather than Limited English Proficient student, the term used in state statute. This follows the precedent set in the reauthorization of ESEA, as amended by the Every Student Succeeds Act.

Language Programs and Locations

In 2024-25, 384 local education agencies (LEAs) in Wisconsin enrolled one or more English Learner students, totaling 55,772 English Learner students enrolled in public and independent charter school districts statewide.[2] This represents 6.9% of the total student enrollment in public and independent charter schools that year. Fifty-eight[3] districts applied to receive state bilingual-bicultural categorical aid for the 2024-25 school year. Those districts served 25,427 ELs who were eligible for state aid.[4] This equates to 45.6% percent of all English Learners enrolled Wisconsin public and independent charter school districts receiving bilingual-bicultural services that were partially reimbursed by the state. Students from nine language backgrounds were supported by the state bilingual-bicultural aid program: Arabic, Chinese, Hmong, Korean, Mandingo, Pashto, Somali, Spanish, and Swahili.

[1] An English Learner (EL) student is defined in federal law as a student whose proficiency in English impacts their academic performance. The complete definition can be found here: 20 USC § 7801(20)
[2] The number of LEAs reporting EL students includes both public school districts and independent charters. Only public school districts may participate in Wisconsin's bilingual-bicultural state aids program. In 2024-25, 365 public school districts had at least one EL student enrolled.
[3] Lake Geneva J1 School District and Lake Geneva-Genoa City UHS School District receive a single payment that is paid to Lake Geneva-Genoa City UHS. However, the districts report data separately and are counted as separate LEAs for the purpose of this report.
[4] An EL student is eligible for state aid if they are part of a language group that meets statutorily set numbers and is served by appropriately qualified staff.

Bilingual programs provide EL students with instructional support in their home language. This instruction can be delivered by a teacher with a bilingual license or, for students who are not Spanish speakers, by a teacher with an English as a Second Language (ESL) license and a bilingual aide. EL students not receiving bilingual services must be served by other types of language instruction educational programs, such as English as a Second Language (ESL) program models. Per Wisconsin Statute 115.95, only students served in bilingual programs are eligible for state BLBC categorial aid reimbursement.

The table below includes information about the number of identified EL students in all Wisconsin Local Education Agencies (LEAs), the number of identified ELs in the state's public-school districts, the number of EL students served in state-reimbursed programs, and the number and locations of state-reimbursed programs serving EL students. The data in this table and the rest of this report is drawn from WISEdata and the bilingual-bicultural end-of-year report that participating districts are required to complete on an annual basis.

Table 1. 2023-24: Languages and Program Locations	
Number of identified EL students in all LEAs	55,772
Number identified EL students in public school districts	54,340
Number of EL students served in state-reimbursed programs	25,427
Number of state-reimbursed programs[5]	58
Names of public-school districts receiving state categorical BLBC aid	Abbotsford, Appleton, Arcadia, Ashwaubenon, Baldwin-Woodville, Baraboo, Barron, Beloit, Clinton, Clintonville, D C Everest, Darlington, Delavan-Darien, Eau Claire, Edgerton, Elk Mound, Elkhorn, Fond du Lac, Franklin, Green Bay, Holmen, Howard-Suamico, Janesville, Johnson Creek, Kenosha, Kewaunee, La Crosse, Lake Geneva J1, Lake Geneva-Genoa City UHS, Luxemburg-Casco, Madison, Marshall, Mayville, Menasha, Menomonie, Middleton-Cross Plains, Milwaukee, New London, Onalaska, Oregon, Oshkosh, Racine, Reedsburg, Sauk Prairie, Sheboygan, Stevens Point, Sun Prairie, Verona, Walworth J1, Waterloo, Watertown, Waukesha, Waunakee, Wausau, West Bend, Whitewater, Wisconsin Dells, and Wisconsin Rapids

[5] See footnote 3, above.

Program Costs for Categorically Aided District Programs

When the bilingual-bicultural state aids program was first established, the appropriation from the state legislature was divided evenly among districts so that each received the same percentage of reimbursement for its approved expenditures. In 1999, Wisconsin Act 9 (the biennial budget) set aside $250,000 from the bilingual-bicultural appropriation. This set-aside was to be divided proportionally among school districts participating in the bilingual-bicultural aid program whose enrollments in the previous school year were at least 15 percent English Learners. The remainder of the appropriation was divided evenly among all the districts according to their approved total budgets. The same formula continues through the current fiscal year. Eleven districts were eligible for this set-aside in 2024-25: Abbotsford, Arcadia, Beloit, Darlington, Delavan-Darien, Green Bay, Madison, Milwaukee, Sheboygan, Waterloo, and Whitewater. Program costs vary from district to district due to several factors, including, but not limited to, the following:

- Number of students served;
- Program and service delivery model, such as in-class vs. pull-out programs, or self-contained programs (e.g., dual language immersion);
- Staff/student ratio;
- Amount of instructional contact time;
- Instructional resources provided (e.g., texts, primary/home language materials and assessments);
- Growth of program and the need to purchase additional materials
- Variety of languages spoken by students and families in a district;
- English-language proficiency level of students and range of proficiency levels among students in a classroom or in a school;
- Amount of previous schooling of English Learners; and
- Outreach and services to EL students and families, immigrant children and youth, or refugee status of students and families.

It is important to note that, even if a school district has English Learners and a bilingual program, it does not necessarily mean that all ELs in the district are enrolled in that program. There are several reasons why this could be so: the bilingual program may be targeted at specific grade levels; the bilingual program may be offered at some schools in the district, but not others; or there could be a bilingual program for one language group in the district that meets the statutorily set threshold numbers, but not for students speaking other languages. The following data tables demonstrate the costs of educating ELs in bilingual programs, as reported by participating districts, and the reimbursement rate for FY25.

Table 2. 2024-25 Program Costs for Categorically Aided District Programs	
Average approved cost/EL student	$4,885.37
Average state reimbursement/EL student (without set-aside)	$386.98
Average state reimbursement/EL student (with set- aside)	$396.81
Number of state-reimbursed programs	58

Table 3. Percentage of Reimbursement to Categorically Aided District Programs Paid in FY25		
Percent of reimbursement to all aided districts except those receiving set-aside	Formula = $\frac{\$10,089,800 - 250,000}{\$124,220,400.82}$	7.92124%
Districts receiving set-aside (EL enrollments of at least 15% of total student enrollment receive a percentage of the set-aside of $250,000)	Abbotsford, Arcadia, Beloit, Darlington, Delavan-Darien, Green Bay, Madison, Milwaukee, Sheboygan, Waterloo, and Whitewater	

Reimbursement Rates over Time

Both the total number of eligible students and the number of districts eligible for bilingual-bicultural categorical aid have increased over the years, as have the approved costs submitted by participating districts. When the funding source was first established in 1975, it reimbursed school districts for a substantial percentage of their allowable costs. However, the percentage of approved costs being reimbursed by state aid has significantly decreased since that time. The amount allocated to BLBC state aids was reduced in FY10 and FY12 and was then flat funded until FY23. During that time, the reimbursement rate fell to a low of 7.7 percent in FY23. As part of the 2023-25 state budget, the appropriation was increased by $1,500,000 for FY24 and FY25. As a result, the reimbursement rate increased slightly to 9.15 percent in FY24. The reimbursement rate fell to 8.55 percent in FY25 due to an increase in the number of districts participating in the program. The 2024-25 biennial budget maintained the increased funding level established in the previous budget but did not include any additional funding. The total amount available for reimbursement for FY 2026 was $10,089,800 and reimbursement rate was 7.92%.

The current BLBC reimbursement rate covers a small portion of the actual costs incurred by districts. Additionally, due to the requirements of the state statute, some districts are not eligible for any reimbursement or receive reimbursement for only a portion of the EL students in the district. As a result of this, as well as the fact that no other state-level funding exists for English Learner students, districts do not receive any funding to support language programming for approximately half of identified ELs in the state. This means that the vast majority of costs associated with providing these required services must be paid for with local funds.

Historical Demographic Data and Number of Reclassified Students

The statistics in the table below trace the history of participation in the state bilingual-bicultural aids program over the past 20 years. This data includes the number of students served in programs receiving categorical aid and the number of students in those programs who became fully English proficient during the school year. The data comes from the certified enrollment data available in WISEdash and the bilingual-bicultural end-of-year report completed by participating districts.

Table 4. Participation in the State BLBC Education Aid Program

School Year	Number of LEAs Reporting EL Students	Total Number of EL Students Reported	Number of Aided LEAs	Number of Eligible EL Students Served	Number of EL Students in Aided Programs Reclassified as Fully English Proficient	Number of Non-Aided LEAs	"Balance" of EL Students
2024-25	384	55,772	58	25,427	1542	326	30,345
2023-24	377	53,474	57	26,948	1,444	320	26,526
2022-23	373[6]	51,638	52	25,155	1,207	321[7]	26,483
2021-22	369	49,812[8]	51	26,610	1,302	318	23,202
2020-21	362	49,528	50	27,129	204[9]	312	22,399
2019-20	361	51,706	51	29,321	1,748	310	22,385
2018-19[10]	365[11]	51,825	53	27,532	1,588	312[12]	24,293
2017-18	361	52,446	53	27,961	1,308	308	24,485
2016-17	357	49,670	52	26,721	496[13]	305	22,949
2015-16	355	48,405	51	25,692	2,336	304	22,713
2014-15	356	49,309	50	24,998	2,031	306	24,311
2013-14[14]	351	49,560	51	23,716	2,319	300	25,844
2012-13	355	50,052	52	26,426	2,910	303	23,626
2011-12	354	51,727	59	27,220	2,627	295	24,507
2010-11	352	51,944[15]	58	28,086	1,846	294	23,858
2009-10	361	52,100	55	26,954	1,860	306	25,146
2008-09	358	51,772	56	27,663	1,401	302	24,109
2007-08	328	45,651	54	27,031	1,415	274	18,620
2006-07	289	40,752	52	26,331	644	237	14,421
2005-06	183	33,402[16]	51	25,081	641	132	8,321
2004-05	267	39,255	49	24,672	1,921	218	14,583

[6] This number was updated from 372 to 373 on 12/17/2024.
[7] This number was updated from 320 to 321 on 12/17/2024.
[8] Due to the impact of COVID-19 on the EL screening process, this number reflects corrected data that was submitted by districts and differs from certified enrollment data.
[9] This number is low due to the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic on some districts' ability to administer the ACCESS test.
[10] Except for 2020-21, from 2018-19 on, the data source used to determine the number of LEAs enrolling EL students and the total number of EL students is the certified enrollment data for all LEAs (i.e., both public school districts and independent charter schools) available in WISEdash. Prior to that year, different data sources were used, which may complicate comparisons of data from 2017-18 and prior years to data from 2018-19 and subsequent years.
[11] This number was updated from 374 to 365 on11/18/2020.
[12] This number was updated from 321 to 312 on 12/17/2024.
[13] This number is low compared to previous years due to a new standard for exiting on the ACCESS test; more information on the WIDA web page.
[14] Beginning with the March 2011 census, and for subsequent years through the 2014 census, different business rules were established resulting in totals that differ from previous years' data. The data in the shaded cells might differ if compared to an earlier report.
[15] Beginning with the March 2011 census, data sources differ from previous years and numbers for PK students identified as EL are again included. The change has caused an apparent drop in the number of ELs, though that drop is more than likely due to the change in data sources.
[16] This count appears low because it does not include most EL migrant students or EL students in PK.

Data Displays

Statewide data from school districts receiving categorical aid for the 2024-25 school year is presented in the following tables.

Table 5: 2024-25 Bilingual-Bicultural Education Programs: Students Served by Language

Language Served	Grade Group PK-3	Grade Group 4-8	Grade Group 9-12	Language Total
Arabic	97	81	23	201
Chinese	34	0	0	34
Hmong	1,197	1,439	725	3,361
Korean	10	0	0	10
Mandingo	12	0	0	12
Pushto; Pashto	38	27	0	65
Somali	88	0	0	88
Spanish	8,353	7,893	5,263	21,509
Swahili	55	26	66	147
Totals:	**9,884**	**9,466**	**6,077**	**25,427**

Table 6: 2024-25 BLBC Education Programs: District Costs and Reimbursement

District Name	Eligible EL Students	Wages and Other Approved Costs	Reimbursement (Aid)	Approved Costs per Eligible EL Student	Reimbursement per Eligible EL Student
Abbotsford School District	433	$800,116	$67,530	$1,848	$156
Appleton Area School District	552	$5,420,512	$429,372	$9,820	$778
Arcadia School District	31	$367,137	$34,728	$11,843	$1,120
Ashwaubenon School District	20	$141,715	$11,226	$7,086	$561
Baldwin-Woodville Area School District	15	$106,495	$8,436	$7,100	$562
Baraboo School District	97	$233,446	$18,492	$2,407	$191
Barron Area School District	72	$357,761	$28,339	$4,969	$394
Beloit School District	1007	$2,691,435	$222,097	$2,673	$221
Clinton Community School District	32	$188,668	$14,945	$5,896	$467
Clintonville School District	24	$72,916	$5,776	$3,038	$241
D C Everest Area School District	328	$1,118,344	$88,587	$3,410	$270
Darlington Community School District	197	$482,370	$40,020	$2,449	$203
Delavan-Darien School District	300	$1,586,020	$128,819	$5,287	$429
Eau Claire Area School District	269	$2,310,150	$182,993	$8,588	$680
Edgerton School District	59	$242,363	$19,198	$4,108	$325
Elk Mound Area School District	12	$97,137	$7,695	$8,095	$641
Elkhorn Area School District	139	$603,766	$47,826	$4,344	$344
Fond du Lac School District	138	$475,460	$37,662	$3,445	$273
Franklin Public School District	79	$185,281	$14,677	$2,345	$186
Green Bay Area Public School District	3293	$14,070,375	$1,153,725	$4,273	$350

District Name	Eligible EL Students	Wages and Other Approved Costs	Reimbursement (Aid)	Approved Costs per Eligible EL Student	Reimbursement per Eligible EL Student
Holmen School District	119	$1,100,748	$87,193	$9,250	$733
Howard-Suamico School District	16	$143,187	$11,342	$8,949	$709
Janesville School District	172	$548,235	$43,427	$3,187	$252
Johnson Creek School District	41	$248,814	$19,709	$6,069	$481
Kenosha School District	279	$1,045,266	$82,798	$3,746	$297
Kewaunee School District	60	$191,913	$15,202	$3,199	$253
La Crosse School District	153	$1,472,558	$116,645	$9,625	$762
Lake Geneva J1 School District and Lake Geneva-Genoa City UHS School District[17]	213	$956,206	$75,743	$4,489	$356
Luxemburg-Casco School District	25	$189,256	$14,991	$7,570	$600
Madison Metropolitan School District	4636	$27,647,157	$2,242,867	$5,964	$484
Marshall School District	117	$567,818	$44,978	$4,853	$384
Mayville School District	42	$133,174	$10,549	$3,171	$251
Menasha Joint School District	273	$3,185,053	$252,296	$11,667	$924
Menomonie Area School District	59	$300,919	$23,837	$5,100	$404
Middleton-Cross Plains Area School District	308	$1,759,859	$139,403	$5,714	$453
Milwaukee School District	5073	$23,827,104	$2,000,496	$4,697	$394
New London School District	87	$191,031	$15,132	$2,196	$174
Onalaska School District	169	$622,457	$49,306	$3,683	$292
Oregon School District	98	$600,959	$47,603	$6,132	$486
Oshkosh Area School District	189	$934,812	$74,049	$4,946	$392
Racine Unified School District	1738	$3,533,227	$279,876	$2,033	$161
Reedsburg School District	61	$57,694	$4,570	$946	$75
Sauk Prairie School District	154	$138,090	$10,938	$897	$71
Sheboygan Area School District	1298	$4,649,783	$384,294	$3,582	$296
Stevens Point Area Public School District	89	$1,285,542	$101,831	$14,444	$1,144
Sun Prairie Area School District	126	$967,321	$76,624	$7,677	$608
Verona Area School District	705	$3,879,427	$307,299	$5,503	$436
Walworth J1 School District	10	$59,979	$4,751	$5,998	$475
Waterloo School District	153	$249,677	$21,105	$1,632	$138
Watertown Unified School District	117	$903,442	$71,564	$7,722	$612
Waukesha School District	767	$7,017,794	$555,896	$9,150	$725
Waunakee Community School District	51	$445,906	$35,321	$8,743	$693
Wausau School District	350	$1,944,741	$154,048	$5,556	$440
West Bend School District	45	$326,335	$25,850	$7,252	$574
Whitewater Unified School District	437	$935,173	$77,943	$2,140	$178
Wisconsin Dells School District	37	$101,732	$8,058	$2,750	$218
Wisconsin Rapids School District	63	$506,545	$40,125	$8,040	$637

[17] Lake Geneva-Genoa City UHS receives a single payment for both that district and Lake Geneva J1 School District.

Table 7: 2024-25 BLBC Education: Student Participation by District and Language

District Name	Language Served	Grade Range	Eligible EL Students	Reclassified English Proficient
Abbotsford School District	Spanish	K4-12	433	24
Appleton Area School District	Hmong	KG-12	500	41
	Spanish	KG-05	52	2
Arcadia School District	Spanish	KG-02	31	0
Ashwaubenon School District	Spanish	KG-03	20	2
Baldwin-Woodville Area School District	Spanish	KG-03	15	0
Baraboo School District	Spanish	KG-12	97	7
Barron Area School District	Somali	K4-03	44	3
	Spanish	K4-03	28	0
Beloit School District	Spanish	KG-12	1007	14
Clinton Community School District	Spanish	K4-05	32	4
Clintonville School District	Spanish	KG-03	24	1
D C Everest Area School District	Hmong	KG-12	311	63
	Spanish	KG-04	17	2
Darlington Community School District	Spanish	K4-12	197	19
Delavan-Darien School District	Spanish	KG-12	300	18
Eau Claire Area School District	Hmong	KG-12	246	33
	Spanish	KG-03	23	1
Edgerton School District	Spanish	KG-08	59	15
Elk Mound Area School District	Hmong	KG-03	12	0
Elkhorn Area School District	Spanish	KG-12	139	16
Fond du Lac School District	Spanish	09-12	138	7
Franklin Public School District	Arabic	KG-12	79	9
Green Bay Area Public School District	Hmong	K4-08	262	39
	Somali	K4-03	44	1
	Spanish	K4-12	2987	132
Holmen School District	Hmong	KG-12	119	18
Howard-Suamico School District	Spanish	KG-03	16	0
Janesville School District	Spanish	KG-12	172	24
Johnson Creek School District	Spanish	KG-08	41	3
Kenosha School District	Spanish	K4-12	279	28
Kewaunee School District	Spanish	K4-12	60	1
La Crosse School District	Hmong	K4-12	153	14
Lake Geneva J1 School District	Spanish	KG-08	149	28
Lake Geneva-Genoa City UHS School District	Spanish	09-12	64	1
Luxemburg-Casco School District	Spanish	K4-03	25	1
Madison Metropolitan School District	Arabic	K4-03	17	1
	Chinese	K4-03	34	5
	Hmong	K4-12	232	23

District Name	Language Served	Grade Range	Eligible EL Students	Reclassified English Proficient
(Madison Metropolitan School District)	Korean	KG-03	10	1
	Mandingo	K4-03	12	0
	Pushto; Pashto	K4-08	65	0
	Spanish	K4-12	4266	218
Marshall School District	Spanish	K4-12	117	11
Mayville School District	Spanish	KG-06	42	4
Menasha Joint School District	Hmong	KG-03	22	0
	Spanish	KG-12	251	21
Menomonie Area School District	Hmong	KG-08	59	4
Middleton-Cross Plains Area School District	Spanish	KG-12	308	23
Milwaukee School District	Arabic	KG-08	95	4
	Spanish	KG-12	4978	150
New London School District	Spanish	KG-12	87	10
Onalaska School District	Hmong	KG-12	169	9
Oregon School District	Spanish	KG-12	98	10
Oshkosh Area School District	Arabic	KG-03	10	0
	Hmong	KG-12	32	1
	Swahili	KG-12	147	1
Racine Unified School District	Spanish	K4-12	1738	86
Reedsburg School District	Spanish	K4-08	61	3
Sauk Prairie School District	Spanish	K4-12	154	7
Sheboygan Area School District	Hmong	K4-12	758	66
	Spanish	K4-12	540	38
Stevens Point Area Public School District	Hmong	KG-08	89	10
Sun Prairie Area School District	Spanish	KG-12	126	6
Verona Area School District	Spanish	KG-12	705	89
Walworth J1 School District	Spanish	K4-01	10	0
Waterloo School District	Spanish	K4-12	153	11
Watertown Unified School District	Spanish	KG-08	117	10
Waukesha School District	Spanish	K4-12	767	45
Waunakee Community School District	Spanish	KG-12	51	1
Wausau School District	Hmong	KG-12	334	57
	Spanish	KG-05	16	5
West Bend School District	Spanish	KG-12	45	3
Whitewater Unified School District	Spanish	K4-12	437	31
Wisconsin Dells School District	Spanish	KG-03	37	3
Wisconsin Rapids School District	Hmong	KG-08	63	4
		Totals:	**25,427**	**1,542**

[END OF REPORT]